

Key Highlights from China's Global AI Governance Plan

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At the World Artificial Intelligence Conference in Shanghai (July 26, 2025), China released a 13-point *Action Plan on Global Governance of AI*. The plan included a proposal to establish an international AI cooperation organization, potentially based in Shanghai. Here's a breakdown of the plan, along with some reflections on its potential impact.

1. **AI as a Global Public Good:** China ties AI to the UN's "*Pact for the Future*" and "*Global Digital Compact*" frameworks, framing AI as a shared international resource.
2. **Core Principles:** The plan stresses people-centricity, sovereignty, development orientation, safety, fairness, inclusiveness, and open cooperation.
3. **Global Infrastructure and Innovation:** The plan calls for investment in clean power, cross-border computing standards, and open access to infrastructure, particularly in the Global South.
4. **Inclusive Innovation and Open Source Ecosystems:** The plan advocates for open source collaboration across borders, non-sensitive resource sharing, and compliance systems for interoperability.
5. **Sector-Wide AI Adoption:** The plan encourages the deployment of AI across various sectors, including healthcare, agriculture, education, manufacturing, and smart cities, with public-private cooperation driving accessibility.
6. **Safe and Controllable Development:** China explicitly calls for AI to be "controllable," with oversight mechanisms ensuring alignment with

national priorities. This point signals strong political interest in embedded governance, not just technical safety.

7. **Data Sharing with Guardrails:** The plan promotes international data collaboration with robust privacy protections, clear legal boundaries, and mechanisms to mitigate bias and discrimination.
8. **Green AI and Sustainability:** The plan includes energy-efficient chips, low-power algorithms, and water consumption standards, as well as AI-driven solutions that support climate and biodiversity goals.
9. **Security, Traceability, and Emergency Coordination:** The plan proposes global frameworks for sharing threat intelligence, incident response, model traceability, and classification systems.
10. **Governments as AI Demonstrators:** The plan suggests that public sector agencies should lead adoption in healthcare, education, and transport, while respecting IP, privacy, and compliance standards.
11. **Standards Harmonization (ISO/ITU/IEC):** The plan calls for faster participation in global standards to shape norms on AI ethics, safety, and interoperability.
12. **Capacity Building and Digital Inclusion:** The plan proposes training programs, joint labs, shared datasets, and AI literacy initiatives targeting underserved groups, especially women and youth.
13. **Inclusive, Multi-Stakeholder Governance:** The plan advocates for global dialogue platforms that bring together governments, researchers, companies, and civil society to form a unified governance loop.

High-level Takeaways

- **China isn't playing catch-up** (as some other blogs I read imply). China is trying to shape the governance stack. From open source norms to green computing, China aims for the infrastructure layer to align with its own regulatory and sovereignty principles.
- **We might expect divergent frameworks.** Countries in the Global South may lean toward China's infrastructure-led offer. Others will stay within Western legal and technical frameworks (read my reflections on the US AI Action Plan). Fragmentation could be the new baseline.
- **AI governance is now a form of political engineering:** Managing source code use, compliance, and contributions isn't enough. OSPOs, policy teams, and global engineering leaders must translate between legal frameworks, technical systems, and geopolitical considerations.

If you lead or influence AI strategy, OSPOs (open source AI), or engineering policies, I would suggest preparing your teams to:

- Map AI alignment across jurisdictions: Essentially, understand where your stack intersects with diverging standards, particularly in compute, data, and traceability.
- Instrument everything for traceability: Model lineage, licensing, data sourcing, and audit trails are a necessity going forward.
- Engage early in standards bodies: Be proactive in ISO/ITU/IEC efforts. These bodies can't and should not become one-sided.
- Adapt OSPOs to handle geopolitics: OSPOs must evolve beyond license compliance to become strategic advisors on cross-border AI risk, policy alignment, and infrastructure adaptability. I've covered this topic a few times before (The OSPO is evolving. Is yours keeping up?, Open Source and Geopolitics: What US Open Source Program Offices (OSPOs) Must Prioritize Now, How OSPOs in the EU are stepping up in a shifting regulatory era, and Navigating Open Source Amid Geopolitical Complexity).

Call to Action for Open Source Foundation: Keep Open Source AI Global

As AI governance models diverge across regions, open source foundations have a unique responsibility to prevent fragmentation by aligning on open source AI principles, open source AI definition, building bridges across OSPOs globally, engaging with policymakers, and investing in tooling that supports multi-jurisdictional compliance. Open Source Foundations could also launch awareness efforts to reinforce that open source is not a geopolitical tool, and emphasize that open source is a shared infrastructure for global innovation.

Conclusion

China's Global AI Governance Plan shows where things are headed. It is both a policy framework and a signal that the rules of the game are being written now. If open source foundations and global developer communities aren't engaged, they risk becoming bystanders in a fragmented AI future shaped by state-led agendas. The call to action is clear: coordinate globally, speak with purpose, and defend the core values of openness and collaboration. The alternative is watching open source fracture along geopolitical lines.

Thanks for reading. Please feel free to share this summary with your network if you find it helpful.

About the Author

Dr. Ibrahim Haddad is Head of Infotainment at Volvo Cars, where he leads the development of next-generation in-vehicle infotainment systems. He previously

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